



police was clearly visible in the video footage shown in the film. "Our biggest difficulty today is making land available for industrial use," Sabyasachi Sen, the state's commerce secretary, confesses. He would like to state that investors are still pursuing Bengal but Sen and his colleagues in the West Bengal bureaucracy are desperate for success stories. An investor-unfriendly image paralysed the state till the mid-1990s and lib-

eralisation of the national economy had only limited success in Bengal towards the end of the decade. Despite the hype created by the Bhattacharya administration, private investment in the manufacturing sector was only Rs 3,490 crore last fiscal and was just Rs 2,519 crore in 2005. The one major success in the manufacturing sector in the last one year has been the Rs 35,000 crore investment by the Jindals for a 10 million tonne steel project in Salboni.

The state's Commerce Minister Nirupam Sen has been planning a visit to California to scout for foreign investment in manufacturing since only Rs 829.56 crore of FDI came to the state last year. Canadian consultancy Webcon has been hired by the state administration to study the investment climate and offer innovative solutions. Though a foreign firm may have been appointed as an advisor, the reality is that the state still does not have a blueprint for development. "Radical changes may not be a good idea for the state," says state Sports and Transport Minister Subhash Chakraborty. Loopholes in the public administration system had resulted in food riots a while back but instead of looking

within, CPI(M) immediately issued a statement calling reports on the food riots politically motivated.

Deviations from the party line or deaths of innocents do not, however, appear to affect the party high command's tolerance of Bhattacharya. Perhaps, his being chief minister of the world's longest running democratically-elected Communist government makes all the difference. Other leaders haven't had it that easy. The conflict that played out in the media between Kerala Chief Minister V.S. Achuthanandan and his state's CPI(M) secretary Pinarai Vijayan led to both of them being suspended from the Politburo for four months. Achuthanandan, like Bhattacharya, is an election winner, but that did not make the Kerala leader worthy of equal treatment in the eyes of the central command. Vijayan too is a powerful CPI(M) leader, but was suspended for encouraging factionalism.

As the bubble bursts around Bhattacharya and the potholes on Kolkata's roads increase, CPI(M) is probably watching a man who makes little of the opportunities at hand even with the concessions his own party grants him. ■

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